There is no shortage of anxieties these days, but more and more adults are facing uneasiness about finances. Worrying about not having enough money to pay for certain things is just one thing, but thinking about money in general causes anxiety among many individuals. Changes in the economy can affect people in different ways—while one may feel the pressure of rising prices, another may worry about job security, savings or debt servicing. Even when nothing has gone seriously wrong, the climate of uncertainty can still create stress.

If you are the sort who wakes up in the middle of the night because of a money-related panic attack, you are not alone. The paycheque-to-paycheque life is making it hard for many people to focus on other aspects of their lives. It is affecting their sleep, focus at work, relationships, and even leading to their inability to speak to people around them. The strain shapes the choices they make with money, sometimes making things harder. Understanding financial anxiety is a good first step toward managing it. Financial anxiety is often vague and unrelated to any tangible factor, yet it impacts your well-being.

Don't confuse financial stress with financial anxiety. Financial stress is not having enough money for something specific. Financial anxiety is an emotional response to your financial situation. For instance, you may be earning perfectly decent sums and managing your home loan repayment, yet you may worry over a future increase in EMIs. You may also fear losing your savings because of an unexpected medical bill or news about wars. You develop financial anxiety mostly because you fear not having the resources available to meet your needs or face challenges that lie ahead.

The answer to managing financial anxiety goes beyond simple budgeting tips and has more to do with addressing the root causes of these complex emotions about money. Sharing some of your financial concerns with a trusted friend or family member can lighten the emotional load you are carrying. Doing so prevents you from feeling alone in managing the issue and also makes the person aware of your anxiety. There are financial therapists as well as financial planners who can help you overcome it. Don't let your financial anxiety turn into a full-fledged mental illness, which is more difficult to overcome.

SYMPTOMS OF FINANCIAL ANXIETY

Financial anxiety does not look the same for everyone, but there are a few common signs

- **Overspending:** Some people spend more when they feel stressed. They follow retail therapy, going on a spending spree by borrowing more than they can afford. This act leads to more debt and more worry later
- **Fear of spending:** Some are afraid to spend at all, even on necessities. They can cut on essentials like food and clothes, leading to poor health owing to deprivation
- **Trouble managing money:** Because personal finance is rarely taught, many people are unable to manage money on their own. In the absence of parents or a partner who can help, they tend to delay bill payments, ignore budgets, and even looking at their finances becomes overwhelming
- **Obsessive behaviour:** Financial anxiety can lead to habits like being aggressive with investments when they are risk-averse. Often, their actions are contrary to who they really are

the stock market experiences unpredictable, and sometimes sharp, rises and falls. Volatility is caused by a wide range of economic and political factors, from news affecting a particular industry sector to government policy changes and political tensions or upheavals. Anything that creates uncertainty and prompts some investors to sell while others buy can lead to volatility.

In a volatile market, prices are not always an accurate reflection of real worth. A sudden swing up or down can cause an